

to let you use his song? Or do you just upload it and hope that it doesn't get taken down. The world of permissions, copyright infringement and fair use is a murky one. More so online. Read on to find out what is allowed and what isn't.

What is copyright?

Copyright is a type of intellectual property right that lets you own rights over an expression of an idea, but not the idea itself. Simply put you can copyright a song written about sadness" but can't copyright 'sadness' itself.

So, the law gives the holder of copyright "a set of right that only they can exercise and exploit" which include but are not limited to distributing and earning money through the work, creating a derivative of the work and reproducing or reusing it. Anyone else doing the same with your work will be infringing the copyright and breaking a law.

But there is one exception. The work can be used by someone else without taking the permission of the copyright holder if it is "Fair Use".



Copyright laws differ from country to country but efforts have been made to standardize them through international copyright agreements

What is fair use?

"Fair use" is a set of exceptions that lets people use copyrighted material for academic, entertainment and other non-commercial purposes if they follow a certain set of guidelines. This exception was actually introduced so that copyright laws do not close the door shut on the possibility of progress of a person's work by someone else.



Fair use is an important and necessary safeguard

So while uploading and downloading files from torrent is copyright infringement, distributing a photo of the periodic table in your class comes under fair use.

So how do you decide if something comes under fair use or is a copyright infringement? You follow the fair use guidelines